

The Violent Effects of Apex Corruption

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Abstract

We document that *apex* corruption scandals—corrupt acts implicating top-level politicians—cause immediate and persistent increases in violent protests across Latin America. Using a panel of 176 corruption scandals across 23 countries from 2008 to 2018, merged with daily protest counts, we establish three facts. The daily count of violent protests increases by about 59% in the month immediately after a scandal; peaceful protests are largely unaffected. The effect appears within a week of the scandal and remains positive even four months later. The magnitude scales sharply with the political rank of the implicated agent: scandals involving sitting Presidents generate effects an order of magnitude larger than those involving Governors, Supreme-Court Justices, or members of Congress. Our findings identify a high-frequency, high-magnitude channel through which corruption shapes the political environment in democracies.

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Political violence is among the most consequential outcomes a democracy can experience. Civil unrest disrupts economic activity, displaces investment, and—when met with state violence in return—erodes the social contract that legitimizes the regime. An influential economic literature has linked political violence to economic shocks (Miguel et al. 2004; McGuirk and Burke 2020), to commodity rents and conflict networks (König et al. 2017; Dube and Vargas 2013), to the foundations of state capacity (Besley and Persson 2011), and in recent comparative work to abrupt withdrawals of foreign assistance (Rohner et al. 2026). Related work shows that protests themselves can produce durable political effects (Madestam et al. 2013; Bursztyn et al. 2021). The contribution of *political* shocks—events that change citizens’ beliefs about who governs them rather than their material circumstances—has received considerably less attention. We argue that public disclosures of apex corruption are one such shock, and that their behavioral consequences for political violence are large, immediate, and persistent.

Corruption is a long-standing object of empirical study, with known costs for growth and the provision of public goods (Mauro 1995; Treisman 2007; Olken 2007; Olken and Pande 2012; Glaeser and Saks 2006). Citizens’ perceptions of corruption prevalence have risen in the past two decades (Cantoni et al. 2024), and apex scandals—those implicating top-level politicians—have drawn growing attention from news outlets, in part because social media has reduced the cost of diffusing information and enables outlets to reach broader audiences (Enikolopov et al. 2018; Tufekci 2024; DellaVigna and Kaplan 2007). While exposure to apex scandals can produce desirable outcomes such as political accountability or the unwinding of corruption networks (Ferraz and Finan 2011a; Arias et al. 2019, 2022), it can also erode democratic values (Ajzenman 2021; Rivera et al. 2024), depress political participation (Foa et al. 2020), and contribute to the cumulative decay of party systems and democratic institutions (Mainwaring, ed 2018; Levitsky and Way 2010). Public exposure of malfeasance by sitting officials changes what citizens believe about who governs them and about the rules under which the government operates. The most consequential corruption-related political moments of the last decade—Brazil’s Lava Jato¹, for instance—were mobilization events, not electoral ones.

We document that apex corruption triggers immediate and persistent increases in violent protests across Latin American democracies. Using a hand-curated panel of 176 corruption scandals across 23 countries from 2008 to 2018, merged with daily protest counts from the Mass Mobilization (MM) project (Clark and Regan 2016), we establish three facts. First, the daily count of violent protests rises by about 59% in the month immediately after a scandal, while the count of peaceful protests is largely unaffected. Second, the effect appears within a week of the scandal and remains positive even four months later. Third, the magnitude scales sharply with the political rank of the implicated

¹See [this video](#) for more information.

agent: scandals involving sitting Presidents generate effects substantially larger than those involving Governors, Supreme-Court Justices, members of Congress, lower judiciary, or other lower officials.

1 Method

1.1 Study Design and Measures

The empirical analysis exploits the as-good-as-random timing of corruption scandal disclosures in Latin American news outlets between 2008 and 2018. We use a stacked difference-in-differences design that compares the evolution of protest activity around the disclosure date of each scandal to the evolution observed in the same country in the days leading up to it. The analysis dataset is constructed by: (i) scraping the Twitter accounts of Latin American news outlets to identify the calendar date on which a scandal in a given country is first reported²; (ii) building a $\pm T$ -day event window around each scandal for $T \in \{30, 120\}$; (iii) merging the country-day count of protests from the MM data to create a scandal-window panel; and (iv) appending these panels into the stacked analysis dataset.

The MM dataset covers 1990–2020 and records the date, size, and location of any episode in which 50 or more protesters publicly demonstrate against the State. If a protest lasts X days, we code its occurrence at dates $t, t + 1, \dots, t + X - 1$. Where the same event is associated with more than one date in the source, we keep the earliest. A protest is classified as “violent” when “the violence could include anything from riotous behavior that destroys property to shooting at the police or military.” We restrict the sample to 2008–2018, the period for which our corruption-scandal catalog is uniformly populated.

We estimate the following equation by Ordinary Least Squares using `reghdfe` (Correia 2017)³:

$$Y_{c(s)t} = \beta \mathbb{1}\{t \geq \text{Scandal Date}_{c(s)}\} + \alpha_d + \lambda_m + \theta_{cy} + \varepsilon_{c(s)t}, \quad (1)$$

where α_d are day-of-week fixed effects, λ_m are month-of-year fixed effects, θ_{cy} are country-by-year fixed effects, $\text{Scandal Date}_{c(s)}$ is the disclosure date of scandal s in country c , $Y_{c(s)t}$ is the outcome of interest, and $\varepsilon_{c(s)t}$ is an idiosyncratic error term. To trace dynamics we replace the post-scandal indicator with a saturated set of bin indicators for time to/since the scandal: 6-day bins at the narrow ± 30 -day window and 30-day bins at the wide ± 120 -day window, with the bin immediately preceding disclosure as the

²We keep the date of the first news report to estimate the effect of the initial scoop and to avoid double-counting through follow-up coverage.

³In the Supplementary Materials we estimate the analogous specification by Poisson quasi-maximum likelihood to account for the count nature of the outcome, and find similar effects. Robustness exercises using modern stacked and heterogeneity-robust difference-in-differences estimators (Cengiz et al. 2019; Sun and Abraham 2021; Borusyak et al. 2024; de Chaisemartin and D’Haultfoeuille 2024) are reported in the Supplementary Materials. ACLED data (Raleigh et al. 2023) provides an independent cross-validation source from 2018 onward, and yields a comparable sign-and-significance pattern on the post-2018 sub-sample.

reference category.

The identifying assumption is that, conditional on the three sets of fixed effects, the within-year date of a scandal’s public disclosure is as-good-as-randomly assigned in relation to the country’s protest baseline. The country-by-year fixed effects absorb every source of country-year-level confounding (electoral calendars, ongoing institutional reforms, pre-existing political instability); the day-of-week and month-of-year fixed effects absorb weekly and seasonal cycles in protest activity.

2 Results

Table 1 reports OLS (Panel A) and Poisson QML (Panel B) estimates of the effect of apex corruption on violent and peaceful protests at the ± 30 -day and ± 120 -day windows. Under OLS, the daily count of violent protests rises by 0.016 events per country-day in both windows ($P < 0.01$ at ± 30 days; $P < 0.05$ at ± 120 days)—roughly 59% of the pre-scandal-bin mean of 0.027 violent protests per day at the narrow window. Peaceful protests do not respond reliably under OLS in either window. The Poisson estimates—which handle the heavy mass at zero in the daily protest count—imply substantively large proportional effects: violent protests rise by 54% at the narrow window and 63% at the wide window. Peaceful protests respond in opposite directions on the two horizons: a 25% increase at ± 30 days and a 21% decrease at ± 120 days, both significant at the 10% level. The opposite-signed peaceful response across windows is consistent with a substitution from peaceful to violent mobilization on the longer horizon, though our specification does not identify substitution directly.

Figure 1 traces the dynamics of the response across the ± 120 -day window using a saturated set of 30-day-bin indicators for time-to/since-scandal in place of the post-scandal indicator. Violent protests (Figure 1a) show no pre-trend in the four pre-scandal bins, jump in the first post-scandal bin, and remain positive and statistically distinguishable from zero throughout the four months that follow. Peaceful protests (Figure 1b) follow a different trajectory: the coefficients are flat through the pre-scandal period and the first post-scandal bin, and then drift negative in the later post-scandal bins. The contrast in dynamics reinforces the substitution reading of Table 1: violent mobilization is the durable component of the response; peaceful mobilization is initially unaffected but is then displaced.

Figure 2 characterizes heterogeneity in the protest response across the political rank of the implicated official. We re-estimate Equation 1 separately for each of the 176 scandals on its own country’s ± 30 -day window, retaining the day-of-week and month-of-year fixed effects, and summarize the cross-scandal distribution of the resulting per-scandal coefficients $\hat{\beta}_s$ by box plot. Scandals are partitioned into three categories: *President* (sitting heads of state, 45 scandals); *Other Apex* (Governors and Supreme-Court Justices, 19 scandals); and *Other Non-Apex* (members of Congress, lower judiciary, and lower officials,

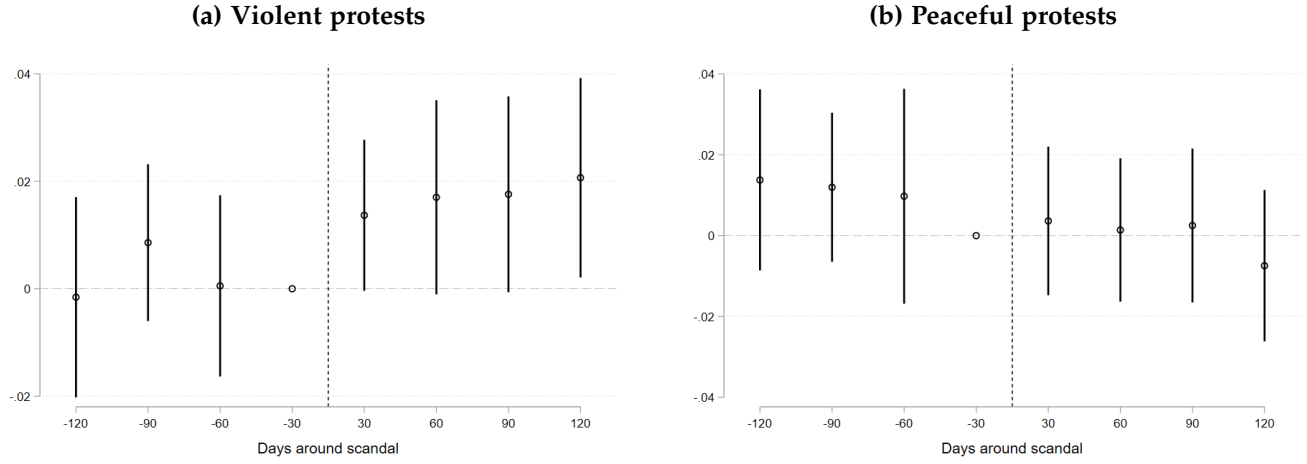
Table 1. Apex Corruption Scandals and Protests: OLS and Poisson estimates

	± 30 -Day Window		± 120 -Day Window	
	(1) Violent Protests	(2) Peaceful Protests	(3) Violent Protests	(4) Peaceful Protests
<i>Panel A: OLS</i>				
Post Scandal	0.016*** (0.005)	0.010 (0.008)	0.016** (0.006)	-0.009 (0.007)
Mean (Pre-Scandal Bin)	0.027	0.069	0.020	0.053
Observations	10736	10736	42657	42657
Number of Scandals	176	176	176	176
R-squared	0.160	0.473	0.126	0.300
<i>Panel B: Poisson QML</i>				
Post Scandal	0.433*** (0.097)	0.227* (0.122)	0.490** (0.195)	-0.240* (0.138)
Implied Prop. Effect	0.542*** (0.149)	0.254* (0.152)	0.632** (0.318)	-0.213** (0.108)
Mean (Pre-Scandal Bin)	0.072	0.114	0.039	0.067
Observations	3996	6454	21585	33529
Number of Scandals	74	108	98	149
Pseudo R-squared	0.317	0.424	0.259	0.295
Country $\times$ Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
SE Cluster	C $\times$ Y $\times$ DB	C $\times$ Y $\times$ DB	C $\times$ Y $\times$ DB	C $\times$ Y $\times$ DB

The table reports OLS estimates (Panel A) and Poisson QML estimates (Panel B) of β from Equation 1 for four outcome-window combinations: violent and peaceful protests, each estimated on the ± 30 -day window (columns 1–2) and on the ± 120 -day window (columns 3–4) around each scandal’s public-disclosure date. An observation is a country-day inside the event window of a scandal; the 176 apex corruption scandals across 23 Latin American countries are stacked. All specifications include country-by-year, month-of-year, and day-of-week fixed effects. Standard errors (in parentheses) are clustered at the country $\times$ year $\times$ day-bin level. In Panel B, the Poisson QML coefficient is on the log scale; “Implied Prop. Effect” reports the implied proportional effect $\exp(\beta) - 1$, with the delta-method standard error in parentheses below. “Mean (Pre-Scandal Bin)” is the average value of the outcome in the bin immediately before the scandal’s disclosure—a 6-day bin in columns (1)–(2) and a 30-day bin in columns (3)–(4)—computed over the corresponding regression sample. The Poisson sample is smaller than the OLS sample because `ppmlhdfc` drops observations that are either singletons or separated by a fixed effect. The sample period is 2008–2018; Venezuela is excluded. Significance: * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

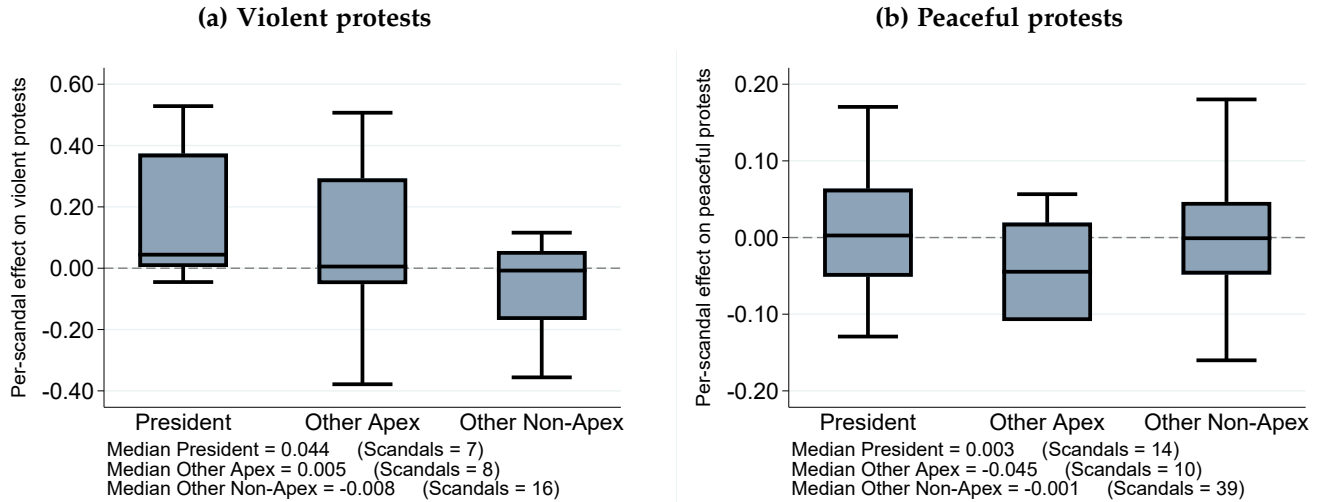
112 scandals). For both violent and peaceful protests, the President distribution sits markedly above the Other-Non-Apex distribution, with Other Apex sitting between the two. The gradient is sharpest for violent protests, where the President median is roughly an order of magnitude above the Other-Non-Apex median.

Figure 1. Dynamics of violent and peaceful protests around apex corruption scandals, ± 120 -day window



Each panel plots the coefficients on 30-day-bin indicators of time-to/since-scandal from the modified version of Equation 1 described in the text. The omitted reference bin is the one immediately before public disclosure ($w_{s,t} \in [-30, -1]$). Vertical bars are 90% confidence intervals constructed from the country $\times$ year $\times$ day-bin clustered variance. The sample includes all 176 apex corruption scandals across 23 Latin American countries; sample period is 2008–2018; Venezuela is excluded.

Figure 2. Per-scandal effects of apex corruption, by political rank of the implicated official



For each of the 176 apex corruption scandals, we estimate the OLS post-scandal coefficient of Equation 1 on the ± 30 -day window of the implicated country alone, retaining the day-of-week and month-of-year fixed effects. Each panel summarizes, by box plot, the cross-scandal distribution of those per-scandal coefficients $\hat{\beta}_s$ for the corresponding outcome under the apex partition: President (45 scandals), Other Apex (19 scandals; Governors and Supreme-Court Justices), and Other Non-ApeX (112 scandals; members of Congress, lower judiciary, and lower officials). The note inside each panel reports the within-category median of $\hat{\beta}_s$ and the number of scandals contributing to each category. For some scandals the outcome has no within-window variation—i.e., the implicated country recorded no protests of the relevant type throughout the ± 30 -day window—in which case the per-scandal regression cannot identify an effect and the scandal is dropped from the corresponding box plot. Outliers are hidden for legibility. The sample period is 2008–2018; Venezuela is excluded.

3 Discussion

Taken together, our three facts are suggestive of a particular reading of how corruption interacts with the political environment of a democracy. Citizens do not respond uniformly to all corruption: they respond sharply, immediately, and durably when the implicated official is at the apex of the political hierarchy, and they barely respond at all when the implicated official is further down the hierarchy. The response is concentrated on the violent margin and persists on a horizon over which institutional adjudication is slow, while the peaceful-mobilisation margin attenuates—and in our Poisson estimates reverses sign—by the four-month mark. We read this constellation as suggestive of three claims that we develop in the remainder of this section. First, corruption is a tangible behavioural shock to a democracy’s near-term political environment, not only an attitudinal one. Second, the political weight of the implicated official—the stakes citizens hold in that official’s continuation in office—governs whether disclosure mobilises citizens to act. Third, when citizens lose confidence in institutional channels of accountability, the composition of mobilisation shifts from peaceful to violent forms.

Our findings contribute to three connected literatures. First, the economics-of-conflict literature has documented that political violence responds to *economic* shocks—rainfall and crop prices (Miguel et al. 2004), commodity rents and conflict networks (König et al. 2017; McGuirk and Burke 2020; Dube and Vargas 2013), the state-capacity foundations of political violence (Besley and Persson 2011), the economics of counterinsurgency (Berman et al. 2011), and abrupt withdrawals of foreign assistance (Rohner et al. 2026). We introduce a *political* shock—public disclosure of apex corruption—and show that it produces a violent-protest response of comparable magnitude to the economic shocks the literature has emphasised. Second, the corruption-and-accountability literature has documented that disclosures of malfeasance change voting behaviour, particularly at the municipal level (Ferraz and Finan 2008, 2011b,a; Avis et al. 2018; Arias et al. 2019). The slow electoral horizon has tended to obscure that the same disclosures can have very fast, non-electoral consequences (Madestam et al. 2013; Bursztyn et al. 2021). Our high-frequency design uncovers a channel through which apex corruption shapes the political environment of a democracy within days of public disclosure, well before any subsequent election can adjudicate. Third, the protest channel we document is the behavioural counterpart of the attitudinal evidence in our companion paper (Rivera et al. 2024), which documents that apex scandals erode citizen support for democratic institutions and depress political participation. Read together, apex corruption operates through a coherent mechanism that affects both citizen beliefs and citizen actions, and contributes to the cumulative erosion of democratic legitimacy that the literature on democratic backsliding has documented (Levitsky and Way 2010; Mainwaring, ed 2018).

Our results help reconcile a set of mixed estimates in the existing literature on the political consequences of corruption disclosure. Studies of municipal-level corruption have produced consistently muted estimates of disclosure’s electoral consequences, with some finding modest accountability gains in Brazil and Spain (Ferraz and Finan 2008, 2011a; Avis et al. 2018; Costas-Pérez et al. 2012) and others finding null or even demobilising effects (Chong et al. 2015; Anduiza et al. 2013; Pavão 2018; Arias et al. 2022). We propose that the dispersion in these municipal estimates reflects the limited political stakes at that level: when the implicated official is one of many municipal officeholders, citizens have weaker incentives to incur the costs of mobilisation. Our apex partition makes this argument quantitative. Within our own sample, scandals against Congressmen, lower judiciary, and lower officials—the closest analogue in our setting to the municipal officials studied elsewhere—have median per-scandal protest effects statistically indistinguishable from zero. Scandals against sitting Presidents, by contrast, have median effects on violent protest roughly eight times larger than those against Governors or Supreme-Court Justices, and an order of magnitude larger than those against lower-rank officials. This is consistent with evidence from Latin American presidential approval data that scandals against sitting Presidents are the political margin at which corruption disclosures have the largest immediate cost (Carlin et al. 2015). The same mechanism that produces muted electoral responses at the municipal level produces sharp behavioural responses at the apex.

A theoretical framework that organises this gradient is the salience-of-stakeholder view advanced by Jha and Shayo (2019), building on earlier work showing that institutional context shapes political behaviour (Jha 2013, 2022; Acemoglu and Robinson 2012, 2006): citizen political behaviour responds to the political weight of what is being disclosed, not to disclosure per se. Under this view, apex corruption mobilises citizens because it changes the perceived stakes of the political bargain—particularly when the implicated official is the sitting executive whose decisions, judicial appointments, and command over policy implementation determine outcomes for the entire country. A purely informational account, by contrast, would predict that the magnitude of the protest response is independent of which official is implicated, conditional on the size of the alleged malfeasance. Our gradient—a roughly eight-fold ratio between the Presidential and Other-Apex medians for violent protests, and an order-of-magnitude gap to the Non-Apex median—is difficult to reconcile with such a pure-information story; the data favour the stakeholder reading. The contrast between high-stakes presidential scandals (sharp response) and low-stakes lower-official scandals (no response) parallels the contrast between high-stakes local elections and routine governance in studies of political accountability (Martinez-Bravo et al. 2022), and is consistent with the broader idea that the supply of citizen engagement depends on whether institutions deliver outcomes (Acemoglu et al. 2024, 2019; Depetris-Chauvin et al. 2020).

The substitution pattern visible in the wide-window event study—violent protests positive throughout the four-month horizon, peaceful protests positive in the immediate aftermath but turning negative by the fourth month (Poisson estimates significant at 10%)—is informative on the same point: it is consistent with citizen mobilisation initially making use of all available channels and then narrowing onto disruptive ones as the institutional response to peaceful mobilisation disappoints. Findings on the erosion of civic and democratic values following exposure to corrupt leaders (Ajzenman 2021; Rivera et al. 2024) are complementary: when citizens perceive that the political elite has defected from the social contract, peaceful mobilisation becomes a less credible means of pressing for change. The mirror pattern in violent government response—which we document in supplementary analysis—is consistent with classical findings that institutional capacity shapes how states meet contention (Davenport 2007).

The empirical exercise has several limitations. First, our identification rests on the timing of *public disclosure* of scandals, not on the underlying acts of corruption. If the timing of disclosures is endogenous to pre-existing political conditions—because prosecutors or media outlets release information strategically in periods of ferment—part of the effect we attribute to scandals could reflect the conditions that surrounded their release. The flat pre-trends in our event studies make the strongest version of this concern unlikely, but our identification is conditional on the timing of disclosure being as-good-as-randomly assigned relative to a country’s protest baseline. Second, our protest data are media-based (Clark and Regan 2016) and therefore under-record small or geographically dispersed events. The cross-source validation against ACLED (Raleigh et al. 2023) on the post-2018 sub-sample preserves the sign and significance pattern of our headline results, but cannot rule out under-recording in earlier years. A substantial share of our scandals—145 of 176 for violent protests—fall in country-windows with no recorded movement on the relevant margin throughout the ± 30 -day window, so the per-scandal heterogeneity analysis in Figure 2 is identified on a selected sub-sample of countries with at least some recorded protest activity. Third, our observational design cannot fully separate the political stakes of an apex scandal from its press salience: apex scandals are disclosed against a backdrop of greater media coverage, and a substantial body of work shows that media coverage independently shifts political behaviour (DellaVigna and Kaplan 2007). We cannot hold coverage constant in our data. The randomised field experiment of Rivera et al. (2024), which experimentally varies the rank of the implicated official while holding coverage constant, provides indirect evidence that the gradient is not driven by coverage alone. Fourth, the apex partition relies on hand-coding of scandals into categories. Finally, our sample is restricted to Latin America between 2008 and 2018; whether the gradient documented here generalises to other regions and to scandals in older democracies is a question we leave open for future work.

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A Raw protest counts around scandal disclosure

We aggregate event-time into 3-day bins (matching the modern-DiD bin convention used elsewhere in the project), bin $b = \lfloor t/3 \rfloor$ for $t \in [-120, +120]$ days, and sum the daily country-level count of protests across all 176 apex corruption scandals inside each bin. The figures show the raw protest counts that the OLS and Poisson estimates of Table 1 summarize. ?? reports the narrow ± 30 -day window; ?? reports the wide ± 120 -day window.

